

Heinrich Popow, London Paralympics gold medallist in the 100m T42, taught us how to use blades. We also got one piece free from that running clinic," says the 25-year-old.

When that blade became soft after considerable use, his father, an insurance agent, had to take a loan to buy a new one, as a piece cost around Rs. 4.5 lakh.

In such a scenario, he could not afford to have more than one blade even when travelling for competitions, and if it malfunctioned, there was no scope for replacement. "When I travel with a blade, I have trained on it for a longer time. So, we hope that nothing happens to the blade. But at the World Junior Championships in 2019 in Dubai, the nut and bolt of the blade, which connects to the socket, got loose and it started to move a little from the socket. I couldn't do anything since it was a major issue," he says.

Since last year, Desai has been a beneficiary of the Khelo India scheme, receiving support from organisations such as GoSports Foundation and AMM Foundation with regards to his training, equipment and other needs.

Money matters: In wheelchair racing the expenses are enormous, a major reason it has struggled to join the growing wave of para-athletics in India. According to Ankur Sagar, the cost of a decent racing wheelchair may start from Rs. 4 lakh. Meanwhile, in club throw (**below, right**), participants are required to sit in a throwing frame within a marked circle and throw wooden clubs. Pranav Soorma reveals a throwing frame can cost around Rs. 50,000.

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Impact of both kinds

World Para Athletics revisited classification and introduced new categories after bringing in a new formula in 2018, which significantly reduced the maximum allowable standing height for double-leg amputees.

It affected athletes such as Shalini Saraswathi, who represented India in the women's 100m T64 event at the Hangzhou Asian Games. "In 2019, I went to China but wasn't allowed to compete since the blades I had were significantly taller and didn't pass the

new rules. I wasn't allowed to race and had to come back to get the blades changed," she says.

Twenty-seven sportspersons from para athletics are part of the TOPS Core Group. They receive INR 50,000 per month as out-of-pocket allowance, plus full funding for their training plans from the government as they prepare for major events such as the Asian Games and the Paralympic Games.

The number of parathletes receiving assistance under the Khelo India Scheme is around 40. These athletes get Rs. 10,000 per month as out-of-pocket allowance and further support through accredited Khelo India Centres with access to training facilities.

Scope for improvement

While the World Championships in New Delhi is a momentous occasion to showcase the country's potential as the organiser of a major event, it also offers an opportunity for domestic brands to learn and adapt to the needs of Indian parathletes in terms of equipment manufacturing, by observing the gear used by athletes from around the world.

« At the World Championships in New Delhi domestic brands can learn and adapt to the needs of Indian para-athletes in terms of equipment manufacturing »»

